MONSTER

HFJ Ballard

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For Kelly,
If there is anything wholesome in these pages, it was inspired by you.

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Part 1

Chapter 1



THE BIRTH was unusually painful; the delivery, unusually incompetent; the doctor, unusually late; the epidural, unusually weak; the bill, unusually high; and the tiny baby boy—wet with amniotic fluid and greatly upset by the ordeal of his much too small passage into a much too large world—simply unusual.

"That is," said the nurse, an unpleasant woman who had gone through more good-natured husbands than there are days in a week, "a child too ugly to be human."

She was wrong, of course. The poor child was not ugly at all, just *unusual*—which is a word that means "not like other little boys." And though it sometimes makes otherwise well-disposed people feel uncomfortable for no reason at all, it is neither a good thing nor a bad thing. It is a thing that just is.

"You're right at that," said the other nurse—a man who, as it happened by a terrible scheduling mistake on the part of the hospital, was the unpleasant nurse's husband. (She, having exhausted the good-natured supplies, had drawn this domestic partner from the rubbish-bin of human personalities.)

"Good heavens," said the doctor. "I've got to run. There are twins being born in room twelve." And, just like a towering cumulus might move in the torrential wind of a hurricane, he disappeared with a flip of his long white coat and the flutter of an unfilled page from his prescription pad.

The baby was—much to his own indignant outrage—cleaned, checked, stared at, questioned, made to perform various uncomfortable tasks such as breathe and swallow, and eventually returned to his female where he was named and, finally, rocked to

sleep. Being of the order that other humans call "the right sort of person," this female to which he had been returned did not see the unusually squashed face, long arms, crooked nose, pinched cheeks, hunched back, colorless eyes, or earless head of her newly arrived son as anything shameful or disappointing. Rather, she thought he was the most perfect bundle of carbon that she had ever seen, and she loved him exactly as he was.

In his wide-eyed, newly arrived way, the sleep-inclined baby thought that she seemed alright, too. And so, in much the way that she had given him a name, he gave one to her. That name was "Mother"—a good name which could also be abbreviated as "Mom," "Ma," "Mama," "Mumsies," "Mamers," or "Mooooooooo."

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The boy grew quickly but unusually. He hit all the right developmental markers at all the wrong times. At one month he raised his head and chest while lying on his stomach. At three months he responded to his own name. At seven months he started recognizing familiar objects. At one year he began to explore with his hands and mouth. At two years he began to crawl, three years to walk, and finally, after four laborious years of learning all the buttons and levers that came with moving his unusual body...he began to talk.

It was a disappointment to him, then, that he learned this valuable skill just in time to go to an unpleasant place called "school."

It wasn't what was supposed to happen at school that he minded so much, learning things about numbers like "three" and "four" was alright, and "triangles" practically tickled him purple. But the rest of what happened was confusing and had the nasty effect of making him not want to go to school at all.

That was his first lesson in the thing called "totalitarianism," which he figured to be as much dreck as all the other "isms" including, but not limited to, "capitalism," "communism," "repub-

licanism," and most, but not all, "prisms." His reasoning was as simple as his recently learned one, two, threes. That is:

One: all the "isms" depended upon the usage of little pieces of paper—either green ones that were traded back and forth or white ones that were put in ballot boxes behind curtains or pink ones that were put in mail boxes by roads or soft ones that came out of boxes on cabinets or long ones that were placed in neat rolls near the much-favored water-seats. Having tested the structural integrity of each of the above materials at various points throughout his now five years of existence, the boy had determined that any "isms" which were predetermined by such flimsy material must, themselves, also be flimsy.

Two: the observable effect of all of the "isms" was such that grown people spent long hours doing things that no one liked, for what benefit, the boy could not guess.

Three: the most intolerable result of those effects was that the adults, being made miserable by number two, could not but help force similar miserable activities upon their dependent charges. Namely, day after day the weight of expectation and displeasure compelled the boy to trudge the halls of the school, where, if one were to listen carefully, the quiet moans of children long aged could still be heard.

Unfortunately, being thus armed with a logical analysis of the injustice done daily upon him was of no use. Mother did not listen, and Father could not listen (having already, many years ago, sloughed off as he had sloughed along for an "ism" of his own). And so, to school the boy went each day without fail. Equally without fail, he hated every moment that was not occupied by threes, fours, or triangles.

And so he endured his time with the other children every day for hours and days and weeks and months. During those hours and days and weeks and months, the other kids, who had not yet learned what it was to understand the world, would strut across

the patchy grass of the school's undersized soccer field to corner the boy on his splinter-ridden bench, where he often sat alone. They would say things like, "Hey freak did they forget to put your ears on at the hospital?" and, "You're such a monster, why else would you have such long arms?" or, "You should have put your face on before you stepped on it this morning!" all of which made the boy feel an unpleasant sensation inside, which Mother told him was called "sad," though he preferred the term "inconsolable with a dash of contempt for the limited lexicon of his peers' idiosyncratic calumny" for—though he was not yet using all the words quite right—once he had learned to speak, there was no stopping his genius for vocabulary.

As the other children became less and less inclined to say kind things, he became less and less inclined to listen when they spoke, with the result that he often found his mind wandering over horizons and landscapes and anything that didn't have an unkind word for him. And that, perhaps, is why he first saw it.

***

It was a brisk fall day, one where the air nipped at the ends of fingers and noses but could not reach past the plethora of jackets and scarves, and therefore was not minded a whit nor a whittle. A day which smelled of the sweet, tangy chill of a winter apple. A day when the ground-sky was perfectly clear, so that one wise enough to stop and look would see colors—more colors than can be found in a crayon box—with a clarity normally reserved for dreams and high-definition nature documentaries. It was a day where one could not but help wonder at the yellows and oranges and reds and purples and browns on the trees and the blue blanket of sky nestling the ground and the new white sheet on the mountains.

Certainly, the boy could not help wondering. He wondered at the russet leaves clinging tenaciously to the trees. He wondered at the thorny dried stalks of what had once been a beauti-

ful rose bush. He wondered at the blinding shine of snow which sat lightly on the face of the slopes in the distance.

It was as if, he thought, the rocky monolith had shed its color, rather than simply being covered with white. There could not exist a white capable of covering the past green of summer or more recent rust of fall without some wayward vibrance leaping through the barrier to reveal itself to the world.

He did not know how long he stood, pondering that sight in his own, unusual way—thoughts limited by his scant five years of experience.

Then, time danced on a pinhead. The mountain rippled like a pebbled pond, stretched its lazy bulk, yawned, blinked one enormous eyelid, allowed a pupil (that may well have been a cave large enough to illegally double-park three mail trucks) to dilate, rolled itself over, and promptly fell asleep once more.

The boy found what it was to be frozen with wonder.

The final image of a large and, dare he think, mischievous smile playing on its cliff-face before it was once again no more than an igneous marvel of tectonic trickery, stuck in his mind as he gazed at the mountain's newly exposed peaks, which looked with exactness like the old ones, except that these did not have snow on them.

He would, of course, come to realize later that there had never been any snow at all—that the mountain had simply exposed its white underbelly to the cool of the morning and that, as was the want of mountains the world over, it had again shielded itself with its massive, craggy back as the heat of the day began to be just a little too uncomfortable for the sensitive white surface of the stomach.

The wide eyes of the five-year-old boy were matched only by the roundness of his mouth and the newfound openness of his mind as he ran to share the astonishing news with his classmates, who laughed at him and called him names; his teacher, who dis-